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USC Dornsife

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Education

University of Southern California

Ph.D. Economics (expected) 2027

Harvard University

Visiting Ph.D. Student, Department of Economics 2025–2026

Bocconi University

M.Sc. Public Policy and Political Economy 2019

B.Sc. Economics 2016

Fields

Political Economy, Spatial Economics, Applied Microeconomics

References

Thomas Chaney (Chair)	Augustin Bergeron	Jeff Weaver
USC Economics	Harvard Economics	USC Economics
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Job Market Paper

The Geography of Protests: Spatial Fragmentation, Participation, and Backlash in the George Floyd Movement

This paper studies how urban geography shapes protest dynamics and their downstream effects on voting. I assemble a new dataset on the 2020 George Floyd protests, geocoding 7,920 events to their venues across 368 U.S. metropolitan areas. I document pervasive spatial fragmentation: protests occur simultaneously at multiple venues within the same city. Combining these venues with smartphone location data, I measure flows of people between neighborhoods and protest venues at the census block group level. I then estimate effects on the 2020 presidential election from differences in exposure and participation across block groups within the same ZIP code. Two opposing mechanisms emerge. First, a localized backlash: block groups near protests shift toward the Republican party, an effect that decays rapidly with distance and is driven primarily by violent events (roughly 0.2–0.35 percentage points within three kilometers). It is driven by property damage, concentrated in high-income areas, unrelated to racial composition, and persists through 2024. Second, a countervailing mobilization channel: neighborhoods that sent residents to protests shift toward Democrats and turn out at higher rates, driven by nonviolent participation and broad across the partisan spectrum. Across the in-sample electorate, the two net to a modest pro-Democratic shift of roughly 0.7 percentage points—about 800,000 votes. Individual North Carolina voter files suggest the mechanisms: the backlash is a change in vote choice, not party registration—nearby residents voted Republican while keeping their Democratic or unaffiliated registration, a defection at the ballot box rather than a change in partisan identity—while mobilization works through higher Democratic turnout, not party switching or new registrations. Overall, fragmentation—shaped by urban structure—expands both exposure and participation, while violence governs the strength of the backlash; together they determine whether a movement’s spatial footprint helps or hurts its political allies.

Work in Progress	Congregations and the Market for Urban Floor Space: Evidence from São Paulo The Dynamics of Protest Fragmentation in the Black Lives Matter Movement	
Awards	Dean's Dissertation Completion Fellowship, USC — \$21,218	2026–2027
	Lusk Center for Real Estate Research Award, USC — \$13,500	2026
	Lusk Center for Real Estate Research Award, USC — \$15,000	2025
	Dan James Fellowship, USC — \$40,000	2024–2025
	Summer Research Award (four times), USC — \$4,000 each	2023–2026
Employment	European Central Bank, Frankfurt, Research Intern	2019
	European Commission, Brussels, Economic Analyst	2017–2018
Research Positions	Research Assistant to Augustin Bergeron, USC	2023
	Research Assistant to Ruben Durante, Pompeu Fabra University	2020–2021
	Research Assistant to Vincenzo Galasso, Bocconi University	2019–2020
Teaching	Teaching Assistant, University of Southern California	Fall 2022–Spring 2024
	<i>Introduction to Econometrics</i> (ECON 318), undergraduate	
	<i>Political Economy and Economic Development</i> (ECON 436), undergraduate	
	<i>Intermediate Macroeconomics</i> (ECON 305), undergraduate	
	<i>Macroeconomic Analysis and Policy</i> (ECON 501), master	
	Teaching Assistant, Bocconi University	2019–2020
	<i>Welfare and Politics</i> , master	
	<i>Economics of European Integration</i> , master	
Summer Schools	Summer School in the Economics of Migration, UC Davis	2024
	ACES Summer School in Political Economy, UC Berkeley	2023
Academic Service	Co-organizer, Southern California Graduate Conference in Applied Economics University of Southern California	2023
Research Grants	Weiss Fund Research Grant — \$5,000	2023–2024
Software Skills	Python, R, Stata, MATLAB	
Languages	Italian (native), English (fluent)	
Citizenship	Italian (US F-1 visa)	